

iQOO HACKATHON 2026

Verified Research Dossier

City Battles + Grand Finale

Rules, eligibility, tracks, scoring, schedule, prizes, phone-first constraints, IP, privacy, and source conflicts

Verification standard

Prepared 12 September 2026. Current official City Battles Guide and Terms are treated as primary authority. iQOO Community and Reskilll organizer posts are used for cross-checking. Older Delhi NCR / early Bengaluru event pages are treated as legacy and not applied to the current Aug-Oct City Battles unless the current guide repeats them.

Research scope: iQOO x Reskilll Hackathon 2026, India

1. Executive verification summary

Current series status

The active national series is four 30-hour City Battles: Bengaluru (29-30 Aug), Pune (5-6 Sep), Chennai (12-13 Sep), Hyderabad (26-27 Sep), followed by a 48-hour Grand Finale in Bengaluru (9-11 Oct 2026). Hyderabad is upcoming as of this dossier date.

- Open applications are free. Applicants are shortlisted through idea screening for in-person City Battles.
- Solo builders or teams of 1-3 are allowed. Student and working-professional buckets cannot be mixed within a team.
- The iQOO phone is both a build surface and the required demo/pitch surface. Office Kit bridges phone and laptop.
- The City Battles use seven broad tracks, not rigid fixed briefs: FinTech & Commerce, Smart Education, HealthTech, Productivity, Smart Living, Developer Tools, Open Innovation.
- The Grand Finale has six tracks: Productivity, Smart Living, Developer Tools, Mobility, Community App, Open Innovation.
- Local/open-source models at the core are explicitly rewarded ("brownie points") in the current guide.
- Judging is 100 points: product quality 30, novelty/impact 20, creative phone use 15, technical depth 15, Office Kit use 10, demo/presentation 10.
- Top 6 teams per city advance: 3 student teams and 3 working-professional teams. The guide also allows standout teams beyond Top 6 and direct Finale registrations.
- Current official portal states INR 40,00,000 total across city battles, finale, and special awards. Each City Battle targets INR 6,00,000.
- Original work must be created during the event window. Pre-event idea drafting is allowed; open-source libraries/frameworks and third-party APIs are allowed with attribution; bringing a completed product is not.

2. Authoritative-source hierarchy used

Priority	Source	How used
1	Current iQOO/Reskilll City Battles Guide	Primary source for dates, tracks, scoring, format, build rules, HackTracker, device, conduct, venue/safety and advancement.
2	Current Terms & Conditions (updated 11 Aug 2026)	Primary legal source for eligibility, originality, IP, loaner hardware, prizes/tax, liability and changes.
3	Current Privacy Policy (updated 11 Aug 2026)	Primary source for participant data, telemetry, sharing, security, media and privacy rights.
4	iQOO Community official posts	Cross-check dates, city recaps, participants and promotion; not allowed to override Guide/Terms if wording conflicts.
5	Reskilll organizer blog	Useful explanatory source for prize breakdown, phone-first emphasis and track examples; secondary to the Guide.
6	Third-party press	Used only to corroborate announcements; conflicts are explicitly flagged.
Excluded as current rules	Delhi NCR / early Bengaluru event pages	Different edition with different PS, timing and scoring. Included only in discrepancy appendix.

3. Dates, cities, format and advancement

Stage	Date	Format	Status / note
Bengaluru City Battle	29-30 Aug 2026	30-hour in-person	Completed; official iQOO recap reported 115 participants and 6 winning teams advancing.
Pune City Battle	5-6 Sep 2026	30-hour in-person	Completed; official iQOO recap reported 105 participants and 6 winning teams advancing.
Chennai City Battle	12-13 Sep 2026	30-hour in-person	Scheduled/current on dossier date.
Hyderabad City Battle	26-27 Sep 2026	30-hour in-person	Upcoming; current public Guide still lists venue TBA.
Grand Finale - Bengaluru	9-11 Oct 2026	48-hour in-person	National finale; Friday evening to Sunday evening.

Advancement

- Two evaluation rounds plus Top 10 pitches are used in each City Battle.
- Top 6 teams per city advance: 3 student + 3 working-professional teams.
- The guide says standout teams beyond Top 6 may also receive Finale slots.
- The guide also says builders can register directly for the Grand Finale without qualifying through a City Battle.

Hyderabad venue

As of 12 Sep 2026, the public current Guide still says Venue TBA for Hyderabad. Do not rely on an unofficial venue until the organizer updates the dashboard/email or current Guide.

4. Eligibility and registration rules

- Open to students and professionals.
- Participants under 18 may need parent/guardian consent for in-person attendance.
- Team size is 1-3 builders; solo participation is allowed and solo participants may be matched.
- Teams may not mix the student and working-professional buckets.
- Applicants choose one City Battle and must attend it in person if shortlisted.
- No invitation, referral or campus nomination is required for the City Battle funnel; application is free.
- Idea screening is used to shortlist applicants for the on-ground event.
- Every track is open to both participant buckets unless the event dashboard states otherwise.

5. All current problem tracks / problem statements

Important interpretation

For the Aug-Oct 2026 City Battles, the official guide explicitly says these are broad domains, not fixed briefs. Anything that fits the domain is fair game. Open Innovation is the wildcard.

Track	Runs where	Official scope
01 FinTech and Commerce	City Battles only	Money, payments, commerce, lending, investing and financial inclusion, built for how India transacts.
02 Smart Education	City Battles only	AI-powered learning, tutoring, study workflows, assessment, skilling and classroom operations.
03 HealthTech	City Battles only	AI-powered healthcare, wellness, fitness or mental-health solutions.
04 Productivity	City Battles + Finale	Help people work smarter, automate repetitive tasks, manage time/information, improve workflows and get more done.
05 Smart Living	City Battles + Finale	Smart homes, IoT, connected devices and everyday convenience.
06 Developer Tools	City Battles + Finale	Tools that help developers create, test, deploy or collaborate faster using AI.
07 Mobility	Grand Finale only	Navigation, EVs, public transport, parking or travel experiences.
08 Community App	Grand Finale only	Community app not specific to iQOO, connecting developers/professionals/interest groups, with AI preferably on-device at the core.
09 Open Innovation	Wildcard everywhere	Anything outside the tracks, any domain, with a local or open-source model at the core.

City vs Finale track matrix

Track	City Battles	Grand Finale
FinTech and Commerce	YES	NO
Smart Education	YES	NO
HealthTech	YES	NO
Productivity	YES	YES
Smart Living	YES	YES
Developer Tools	YES	YES
Mobility	NO	YES
Community App	NO	YES
Open Innovation	YES	YES

6. Phone-first build requirements

- The iQOO device is explicitly the build surface and demo surface. Every entry must run and pitch on the phone.
- Office Kit bridges phone and laptop using screen mirroring, clipboard, file transfer and remote control.
- Green Light means phone + laptop are allowed. Red Light means phone-first/phone-only workflow through Office Kit with laptops restricted by the event format.
- Current guide welcomes native Android, Flutter, React Native and PWA stacks if the result runs on the phone and follows the AI requirements.
- On-device inference is targeted at the Snapdragon NPU; the event provides AI credits for the weekend.
- Local/open-source models at the core are not described as a strict universal disqualification rule in the guide, but they explicitly earn extra credit/brownie points and Open Innovation specifically requires local/open-source AI at the core.

Do not overstate the Red/Green percentages

The current official Guide describes the Red Light / Green Light format but does not publish a percentage split on the rule page. A Reskilll organizer blog says 55% Red / 45% Green. Treat that ratio as organizer guidance, not a stronger rule than the live event schedule.

7. HackTracker and device rules

- Each participant receives one flagship iQOO loaner phone at Saturday check-in.
- HackTracker is pre-installed; Office Kit is already paired / pairing is taught at the opening teach-in according to the Guide.
- The loaner remains iQOO property and must stay in the venue/designated hacking zone and be returned before exit.
- Lost, stolen or damaged hardware may be charged to the team under the Terms.
- HackTracker records counts and durations for phone-use and Office Kit scoring.
- The current Guide expressly says HackTracker does not capture keystrokes, screenshots or browsing.

8. Judging and scoring - verified rubric

Criterion	Weight	Source / meaning
End product quality	30%	Jury: working product, usefulness, likelihood users would keep using it.
Novelty and impact	20%	Jury: originality and real-world impact.
Creative phone use	15%	HackTracker device data: camera, voice, on-device AI and creative phone usage.
Technical depth	15%	Jury: architecture, code quality, robustness and real use of hardware.
Office Kit usage	10%	HackTracker device data: phone-laptop bridge usage.
Demo and presentation	10%	Jury: compelling 3-5 minute pitch and live demo on the phone.

What this means strategically

25% of the score is tied to measured phone/Office Kit usage. A strong laptop-only backend with a token phone UI leaves measurable points on the table. The final demo must run on the iQOO phone.

9. Build and submission rules

- Original work only: code must be written during the event window.
- Pre-event idea drafting is permitted.
- You may use open-source libraries/frameworks and third-party APIs with proper attribution.
- You may not bring a completed product and present it as the hackathon build.
- Repository and demo assets must be submitted on Reskill before the hard cutoff; the Guide says repositories are locked before Top 10 pitches.
- Late submission may lead to scoring penalties or disqualification.
- Cheating, plagiarism or unfair practice can cause immediate disqualification.
- Organizers may verify that the project was built during the event window.
- If a technical issue occurs before your judging slot, tell an organizer immediately.

10. Conduct, venue and safety rules

Code of conduct

- Respect participants, mentors, jury, organizers and volunteers.
- Zero tolerance for harassment, discrimination, intimidation or disruptive behavior; immediate removal is possible.
- If something feels wrong, contact an organizer immediately.

Venue

- Report on time; check-in closes according to the city schedule.
- No smoking on premises.
- No alcohol on-site.
- Stay in designated hacking, rest and meal zones; keep noise considerate.

Safety and wellbeing

- First-aid support is on site.
- Alert the nearest organizer in an emergency.
- Take breaks during the overnight sprint.
- Tell a teammate or volunteer if stepping out after dark.

Photography / media

- Event filming and photography may be used for iQOO/Reskill documentation and promotion.
- Check-in consent covers event media use under the Guide.
- Do not film or share another team's screen/build without permission.

11. Intellectual property, prizes, tax and liability

- You retain IP ownership in your submission.
- By submitting, you grant iQOO and Reskill a non-exclusive, royalty-free, worldwide right to review, evaluate and showcase the work for hackathon-related communications.
- Commercial use beyond showcase requires a separate written agreement.
- Judging decisions are final.
- Prize money is disbursed to the registered team leader.
- Tax obligations are the recipient's responsibility.
- Reskill may disqualify entries that breach the Code of Conduct or Terms.
- Reskill/iQOO disclaim indirect or consequential losses arising from participation, hardware use or platform availability; the Terms cap aggregate liability at fees paid (zero for this free event).
- Terms may be updated before the event; material changes are to be communicated by email and posted online.

12. Prize structure - verified and conflict-aware

Safest verified statement

The current official City Battles portal says INR 40,00,000 total across four City Battles, the Grand Finale and special awards. Each City Battle targets INR 6,00,000. Do not describe INR 40L as the Finale-only pool.

City Battle bucket	Winner	1st runner-up	2nd runner-up	Subtotal
Working professionals	INR 1.5L	INR 1.0L	INR 0.70L	INR 3.20L
Students	INR 1.5L	INR 0.80L	INR 0.50L	INR 2.80L
Total city cash				INR 6.00L

Why some online numbers conflict

- The official City Battles Guide says INR 40L is the total series pool across city battles, finale and special awards.
- An official iQOO Community promotional post contains wording that can be read as a "shot at the INR 40 lakh Grand Finale prize pool." That conflicts with the current portal framing and should be treated as promotional shorthand, not the controlling rule.
- Some press coverage reports INR 25L for the Finale. Four city pools at INR 6L already total INR 24L, so adding INR 25L would exceed INR 40L before special awards. The current Guide therefore has higher authority than that press figure.
- The official portal calls each city INR 6L "indicative" and says the balance of the total pool sits with the Finale and special awards. Use the current dashboard/email for the exact final Finale payout when published.

13. Privacy and participant data

- Reskillll may collect name, email, mobile, occupation/education, profile links, location, team/event details, technical telemetry, project submissions/code links/documents and communications.
- Data is used for authentication, coordination, team formation, RSVP/run-of-show communications, service notifications, analytics, compliance, fraud prevention and security.
- Reskillll says it does not sell, rent or trade personal information.
- Data may be shared with iQOO, approved event partners, contracted service providers and when legally required; authorized partners may receive participant data for event-related communications/follow-up.
- Security measures described include HTTPS, hashed credentials, scoped access controls, monitoring and reviews, with no guarantee of absolute security.
- Participant rights include access, correction, deletion subject to retention requirements, promotional opt-out and portability.

14. Current City Battle run-of-show: what is definitely known

Phase	Verified timing / description
Check-in	Around 08:00 Saturday; exact city schedule controls.
Clock start	Saturday 10:00.
Active hacking	From 11:00.
Red / Green phases	Both are part of the 30-hour event. Current Guide does not publish a fixed percentage split.
Evaluation 1	Saturday evening.
Evaluation 2	Sunday morning.
Top 10 pitch	After evaluation rounds; final pitch is 3-5 minutes per rubric.
Awards / close	Around 17:00 Sunday according to Guide; exact city timetable may vary.

Operational rule

Use the city-specific schedule issued to shortlisted teams for exact judging slots and Red/Green transitions. The Guide intentionally uses approximate "around" timings for some operational phases.

15. What every participant is expected to receive / use

- One flagship iQOO loaner phone per participant for the event.
- HackTracker on the loaner device.
- iQOO Office Kit phone-to-laptop bridge.
- AI credits for the weekend.
- On-floor mentors; organizer communications describe 10-15 / 12+ mentors depending on city/promo material.
- Meals/event support are mentioned in organizer blog material; city operational emails remain the final source for logistics.

16. Office Kit: what it does - and what it does NOT prove

Capability	Verified status
Screen mirroring	Explicitly listed in current Guide.
Shared clipboard	Explicitly listed in current Guide.
File transfer	Explicitly listed in current Guide.
Remote control	Explicitly listed in current Guide.
HackTracker scoring of Office Kit use	Explicitly listed; worth 10% of total score.
General programmable RPC/API for your own agent	NOT stated in the current hackathon Guide. Do not assume Office Kit exposes a developer RPC API unless iQOO separately documents one.
Arbitrary structured messages from Android app to laptop agent	Not established by the public rules. If needed, build your own authenticated HTTPS/WebSocket/local bridge within event rules.

17. Legacy pages that must NOT be mixed with the City Battles

Why this matters

Search engines still surface early-2026 iQOO Hackathon pages. They are real, but they describe previous events with different problem statements, schedules and scoring. Copying them into a City Battle plan would produce incorrect rules.

Legacy source	What it said	Why not current
Delhi NCR - 6 Jun 2026	8-hour event; AgentKit, Campus OS, BrandForge + Open Innovation; INR 1.8L; different Red/Green timings.	Concluded early event; current Aug-Oct Guide defines a new national City Battle series.
Early Bengaluru page	30-hour event with a smaller INR 3.2L pool and fewer fixed PS; 60/40-style format language.	Predates current 4-city series page and current INR 6L City Battle structure.
Older preparation blogs	May describe 8-hour sprint, different scoring and PS names.	Useful only as historical context; not current rules unless repeated in Aug 2026 Guide.

18. Re-verification conclusions for a Hyderabad participant

- Hyderabad dates: 26-27 September 2026 - strongly verified across current Guide and official iQOO Community announcement.
- Public venue: still TBA in the current Guide as of 12 September 2026.
- Your Developer Tools concept is directly inside Track 06 and that track exists in both City Battles and Grand Finale.
- The product must run and pitch on the iQOO phone. Your architecture can use cloud backends, but phone usage and Office Kit usage are directly scored.
- Your existing completed Bimax product cannot simply be submitted as the hackathon build. You can reuse open-source libraries/frameworks and pre-event ideas, but the submitted product/code must be created during the event window. If you reuse your own prior code, obtain explicit written organizer clarification before relying on it.
- The safest strategy is to build a new phone-first control-plane prototype during the event and integrate permitted third-party services, rather than shipping the pre-existing desktop product itself.
- Local/open-source/on-device AI should be meaningfully present because it is explicitly rewarded and is central to the event identity.
- Keep a clean repo history and timestamped event-window commits; organizers reserve the right to verify build timing.

19. Rule checklist before you arrive

- Confirm Hyderabad venue and reporting time from latest organizer email/dashboard.
- Confirm your team bucket (all students OR all working professionals).
- Ensure team size is 1-3.
- Pick the track in the dashboard; for your current product, Developer Tools is the natural fit.
- Prepare ideas/architecture only; do not bring a completed submission.
- List every open-source dependency and third-party API you intend to use for attribution.
- Install/practice Office Kit before the event if organizer instructions provide access.
- Plan meaningful phone-native functions: voice, camera, local inference, approvals, notifications, mobile UI.
- Plan for a 3-5 minute final pitch on the phone.

- Keep risky production credentials out of the demo; use scoped test accounts/tokens.
- Check the live Guide and Terms again in the final 48 hours because the Terms allow updates before the event.

20. Source register

Access date

All current-rule sources below were checked/re-checked on 12 September 2026.

Tier	Source	URL
Primary	Guide & Rules - iQOO Hackathon 2026 City Battles	https://iqoo.reskilll.com/guide
Primary	Terms & Conditions - iQOO Hackathon 2026	https://iqoo.reskilll.com/terms
Primary	Privacy Policy - iQOO Hackathon 2026	https://iqoo.reskilll.com/privacy
Primary/current mirror	City Battles landing page	https://iqoo-dev.reskilll.com/
Official iQOO community	iQOO Hackathon 2026 - Register Now	https://community.iqoo.com/in/thread/167130
Official iQOO community	Bengaluru City Battle recap	https://community.iqoo.com/in/thread/169162
Official iQOO community	Pune City Battle recap	https://community.iqoo.com/in/thread/169968
Organizer blog	iQOO Hackathon 2026: India's Phone-First AI Hackathon	https://reskilll.com/blogs/iqoo-hackathon-2026-india-phone-first-ai-hackathon-iqoo-reskilll/
Organizer blog	7 Problem Tracks at iQOO City Battles	https://blogs.reskilll.com/7-problem-tracks-iqoo-city-battles-what-to-build-maximum-impact-2026/
Secondary cross-check	IT Voice announcement	https://www.itvoice.in/iqoo-announces-indias-phone-first-hackathon-series-challenging-young-innovators-to-build-ai-powered-solutions-for-real-world-problems-on-mobile
Secondary cross-check	FoneArena announcement	https://www.fonearena.com/blog/489783/iqoo-hackathon-2026-hybrid-mobile-development-challenge.html

21. Final verified rule card

Item	Verified answer
Hyderabad	26-27 Sep 2026; 30-hour in-person; venue publicly TBA in current Guide.
Team	1-3; solo allowed; students and professionals cannot mix.
Cost	Free entry/application.
Track for your dev/team AI idea	Developer Tools.
Phone requirement	Must run and pitch on iQOO phone.
Laptop	Allowed in Green Light; Red Light enforces phone-first workflow via Office Kit.

AI	Local/open-source model at core earns extra credit; AI credits provided.
Originality	Code built during event; no pre-built completed product.
Open source/APIs	Allowed with attribution.
Judging	30 product + 20 novelty + 15 phone + 15 depth + 10 Office Kit + 10 demo.
Pitch	3-5 minutes.
Advancement	Top 6/city: 3 student + 3 professional; standout/direct Finale routes also stated.
Total prize pool	INR 40L across city battles + finale + special awards.
Per-city pool	INR 6L target / indicative.
IP	You retain IP; iQOO/Reskill get non-exclusive showcase/evaluation rights.
Final authority	Current Guide + Terms + city-specific organizer communication.

End of verified dossier